commitments to Myanmar, there is scope for expanding the linkages across the Bay of Bengal as well.

In its own territory too, there are plenty of other options that India can explore to strengthen its maritime influence. The development of the Andaman & Nicobar Islands would surely rank foremost. We should be asking ourselves how other nations would have utilized such a well-located asset. Whether it is Act East, SAGAR, Neighbourhood First or Indo-Pacific, strategy begins at home and it is really progress there that would be a test of seriousness.

In other circumstances, the re-energizing of SAARC should be one of India's key foreign policy priorities. South Asia is clearly among the least integrated regions of the world and being located at the centre of the Indian Ocean, its dysfunctionality affects that larger space directly. The case for building connectivity and expanding trade is glaringly obvious. However, determined opposition to the core agenda from one country undermines much needed cooperation. India, therefore, focuses more on aggregating bilateral and plurilateral initiatives for the moment. Eventually, the hope will be that normalcy will prevail in this area as in others. In the meanwhile, other options like BIMSTEC have to be developed, shifting the focus to the Bay of Bengal.

Strengthening the sense of extended neighbourhood is part of India's reclaiming of history. Its cultural basis is so visible that it needs little affirmation, whether in South-East Asia, the Gulf or Central Asia. Even its economic basis is now increasing gradually as trade, investment and mobility make their impact. What it really lacks is the connectivity underpinning that was disrupted seven decades ago. And the oceans can make a real difference in finding a fix.

The Indian Ocean has been described in one of its histories as a highway linking great multitudes across vast geographies. This critical role can actually be played once again if its centre of gravity acts as a facilitator. That requires a smoother movement of goods and people not only within India but also to its immediate neighbourhood, and beyond. Not coincidentally, stronger connectivity is at the heart of many of India's foreign policy initiatives. A growing commitment to trans-national highway